

CAMBRIDGE O LEVEL ENGLISH LANGUAGE 1123

Improved Teacher Mark Scheme

TEXT A: THE FINAL PERFORMANCE

Question 1: Comprehension | Question 2: Use of Language

QUESTION 1 16 marks	QUESTION 2 9 marks	TOTAL 25 marks
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QUICK MARKING PRINCIPLES

1	Award whole marks only and mark positively.
2	Credit clear alternative answers which communicate the same meaning.
3	Do not require perfect spelling or grammar unless an error makes the meaning unclear.
4	Where own words are required, candidates must rephrase the key meaning rather than copy it.
5	For details or supporting evidence, accurate quotation is acceptable unless own words are specified.
6	Do not award an additional mark for repetition of the same point.
7	In Question 2, naming a technique is not enough; the effect of the actual word or image must be explained.

MARKING MAP

Section	Assessment focus	Marks
Question 1	R1 explicit meaning and R2 implicit meaning and attitudes	16
Question 2	R4 analysis of how writers achieve effects	9

COMMAND-WORD KEY

Command	What the candidate must do	Fast marking check
identify / give	Select the exact detail requested.	Correct detail only
explain in own words	Unpack every key part of the phrase without lifting it.	All strands reworded
give details to support	State the idea, then add distinct textual evidence.	No repeated evidence

QUESTION 1: COMPREHENSION

R1 explicit meaning and R2 implicit meaning and attitudes.

Question 1(a)

From paragraph 1, identify one detail which suggests that the theatre has been neglected.

[1]**EXPECTED ANSWER**

Any one of the following: the building leans over the street; the stone angels are stained by soot; the red sign is missing three letters.

ALLOW

- the building is leaning / appears structurally uncared for
- soot has blackened or marked the stone angels
- part of the theatre sign is missing

DO NOT ALLOW

- the pavement is wet or shiny
- demolition will begin the next morning
- evening is closing around them
- the theatre is old / neglected (too general; no supporting detail)

TEACHER INSIGHT

This is a precise retrieval item. Credit one visible sign of poor maintenance from paragraph 1 only.

Question 1(b)

Using your own words, explain what the text means when Haseeb “attacked the theatre steps with the offended dignity of a king returning from exile”.

[2]**EXPECTED ANSWER**

Haseeb climbed the steps forcefully and determinedly, while behaving with the pride of someone reclaiming a place that rightfully belonged to him after a long absence.

MARKING

- 1 mark: he moved up the steps energetically, forcefully or with determination.
- 1 mark: he acted proudly or majestically, as though returning to/reclaiming a place from which he had been unfairly absent.

ALLOW

- he refused to let the difficult steps defeat or weaken him
- he behaved as if the theatre were his kingdom and he had come back to it
- he climbed with proud defiance despite his age

DO NOT ALLOW

- he literally attacked the steps
- he was angry because a king had sent him away
- “he was offended” without explaining the pride/reclaiming idea
- direct lifting of “attacked”, “dignity”, “king” and “exile” without rephrasing

COMMON ERROR

Explaining only the force of the movement earns 1 mark. The royal-return image must also be unpacked.

Question 1(c)(i)

In paragraph 4, what does Haseeb discover when he brushes dirt from the brass star?

[1]**EXPECTED ANSWER**

He discovers that the star is engraved with both his own name and Sameera Piracha’s name.

ALLOW

- the names Haseeb Piracha and Sameera Piracha are written/engraved on it

DO NOT ALLOW

- he finds a brass star
- he finds only Sameera’s name
- he finds a memorial without identifying the two names

TEACHER INSIGHT

Both names form the discovery. Award the mark only when the response communicates that the star carries the pair of names.

Question 1(c)(ii)

Why does Haseeb cover Sameera’s name with his shoe?

[1]**EXPECTED ANSWER**

Seeing Sameera’s name causes him grief or emotional pain because she has died, so he tries to hide it from view.

ALLOW

- the name brings back painful memories of his wife
- he is not ready to look at or confront the reminder of Sameera
- he is trying to conceal his sadness

DO NOT ALLOW

- he wants to erase her contribution
- he is ashamed of Sameera
- he does not want Abdul Hayee to learn her name
- he is cleaning the star

TEACHER INSIGHT

The action is defensive, not disrespectful: he covers the name because it affects him emotionally.

QUESTION 1: COMPREHENSION

Physical evidence, feeling with support, and inference.

Question 1(d)

Explain what Abdul Hayee notices that makes Haseeb appear taller.

[1]**EXPECTED ANSWER**

When Haseeb steps onto the stage boards, his back straightens, changing his posture and making him seem taller.

ALLOW

- he stands upright / stops stooping when he reaches the stage

DO NOT ALLOW

- the spotlight makes him taller
- he climbs onto a raised platform
- he actually grows taller
- he looks confident (without the physical detail)

TEACHER INSIGHT

The question asks for the observable physical change, not merely the feeling or symbolic transformation.

Question 1(e)

In paragraph 6, how does Haseeb feel after he snaps at Abdul Hayee? Give two details from the text to support your answer.

[3]**EXPECTED ANSWER**

Haseeb feels embarrassed, ashamed, apologetic or regretful after speaking sharply.

MARKING

- 1 mark: a valid feeling such as embarrassed / ashamed / regretful / apologetic.
- 1 mark: "his face softened".
- 1 mark: he makes the self-mocking comment "Though not always steadily" and/or produces a smile that cannot hide his embarrassment.

ALLOW

- remorseful / sorry / uncomfortable about his outburst
- his tone softens
- he uses humour to reduce the tension or indirectly apologise

DO NOT ALLOW

- angry / proud / amused as the main feeling
- "he smiled" alone without connecting it to embarrassment
- repeating the same evidence in two forms

MODEL RESPONSE

Haseeb is embarrassed and regrets snapping at Abdul Hayee. His face softens, and he makes a self-deprecating joke about not always standing steadily to ease the tension.

Question 1(f)

Explain what Haseeb is thinking when he lifts the script "as though it might bruise beneath his fingers".

[2]**EXPECTED ANSWER**

He thinks the script is extremely delicate and must be handled gently, and he regards it as precious because it preserves Sameera's presence and memories.

MARKING

- 1 mark: the script seems fragile, vulnerable or easily damaged.
- 1 mark: it has deep emotional value / represents Sameera / is precious to him.

ALLOW

- he treats the script almost like a living thing that could be hurt
- he fears damaging something irreplaceable connected to his wife

DO NOT ALLOW

- the script can literally feel pain
- Haseeb's fingers are bruised
- it is merely old (without delicacy or value)
- he is frightened of the script

COMMON ERROR

A literal comment about paper being thin earns no mark unless the answer explains careful handling and emotional importance.

QUESTION 1: COMPREHENSION

Selection of evidence and whole-text development.

Question 1(g)

From paragraph 8, give two details which show why Haseeb believes Sameera deserved greater recognition.

[2]**EXPECTED ANSWER**

Award 1 mark for each of any two distinct contributions made by Sameera.

MARKING

- she was the theatre's finest actor
- she rewrote scenes
- she trained younger performers
- she rescued productions when directors lost control

ALLOW

- accurate quotations or clear paraphrases of any two listed achievements

DO NOT ALLOW

- reviewers called her "Haseeb Piracha's wife" (shows lack of recognition, not why she deserved it)
- the booklet mentioned her in one sentence (same issue)
- she had died six years earlier
- two versions of the same contribution

TEACHER INSIGHT

Students must select achievements, not evidence that she was overlooked.

Question 1(h)

Explain using your own words Abdul Hayee's different feelings during the visit to the theatre. Give three details from anywhere in the text to support your answer.

[3]**EXPECTED ANSWER**

Award 1 mark for each distinct, text-supported feeling or attitude. The response should show movement across the visit rather than repeat one idea.

MARKING

Possible stages include:

- initially doubtful, puzzled or dismissive: he wonders why anyone would enter the theatre for one old trunk
- concerned or protective: he helps with the brittle controls / catches Haseeb's elbow
- startled or uncomfortable: Haseeb pulls away and snaps at him
- curious and increasingly understanding: he realises the script contains a part of Sameera photographs cannot preserve
- amazed, absorbed or transported by the performance: he forgets the leaking roof and broken seats; the theatre seems crowded
- moved, admiring or supportive: he claps with enough force to wake echoes
- respectful of the theatre's lasting value: he carries the key and sees the damaged sign as still capable of an encore

ALLOW

- any other distinct feeling that is convincingly supported by a precise detail from the passage

DO NOT ALLOW

- three details expressing only the same feeling
- unsupported labels such as "happy", "sad" or "excited"
- Haseeb's feelings instead of Abdul Hayee's
- copied quotations with no explanation of the feeling

MODEL RESPONSE

At first Abdul Hayee is doubtful because he cannot understand why anyone would enter the ruined theatre for a trunk. He then becomes concerned and tries to protect Haseeb when the controls and loose floor seem dangerous. By the performance, he is deeply moved and absorbed: he forgets the damaged building and applauds hard enough to fill it with echoes.

QUESTION 2: USE OF LANGUAGE

R4 analysis of how writers achieve effects.

Question 2(a)

What two impressions does the writer want to convey about the theatre and Haseeb in the extract from lines 19-22?

[2]**EXPECTED ANSWER**

One impression should concern the theatre and one should concern Haseeb.

MARKING

- Theatre: vast, gloomy, empty, neglected, lifeless or faintly threatening; the rows of "dark mouths" and dusty curtain make it seem abandoned and hungry/silent.
- Haseeb: transformed, revived, proud, confident or restored to his former stature when he reaches the stage; his straightened back makes him seem younger or more commanding.

ALLOW

- equivalent interpretations securely connected to the wording of the extract

DO NOT ALLOW

- two impressions about only the theatre
- two impressions about only Haseeb
- simple paraphrase: "there are many seats and he looks taller"
- identification of "simile" without explaining the impression

TEACHER INSIGHT

The wording of the question deliberately divides the two marks: theatre + Haseeb.

Question 2(b)

What effect does the phrase "resisted us like a rusted bone" suggest about the lever?

[2]**EXPECTED ANSWER**

The lever seems stiff and extremely difficult to move, while the comparison also makes it appear old, seized, brittle or decayed.

MARKING

- 1 mark: force/resistance - the lever is rigid, stuck, unyielding or requires considerable effort.
- 1 mark: age/decay - "rusted bone" suggests deterioration, brittleness, lifelessness or danger of breaking.

ALLOW

- the image makes the mechanism seem almost skeletal, as if the theatre itself is aged or dying
- it takes effort from both characters to force it down

DO NOT ALLOW

- "it is a simile"
- it looks exactly like a bone
- it is rusty (only partial, without developed effect)
- it is strong (contradicts the brittleness/decay of "rusted")

MODEL RESPONSE

The lever is so seized that it seems to push back against them. Comparing it to a rusted bone also suggests age, decay and the risk that it might snap under pressure.

QUESTION 2: USE OF LANGUAGE

Precise word choice and implied emotion.

Question 2(c)

Explain why the writer uses the word “spilled” rather than “shone” in “a single spotlight spilled onto the stage like a pale coin”.

[1]**EXPECTED ANSWER**

“Spilled” makes the light seem to pour, spread or pool across the stage like a liquid, creating a broader and more visible patch than the neutral word “shone”.

ALLOW

- the light flows or spreads beyond a narrow fixed point
- it creates the impression of a soft pool of light appearing on the stage

DO NOT ALLOW

- “spilled” is stronger / more descriptive (without explaining how)
- the spotlight falls over
- liquid literally comes from the light
- it simply means the light is bright

TEACHER INSIGHT

The mark is for the liquid-like movement or spreading effect of the verb.

Question 2(d)

What does the writer want to suggest about Haseeb’s feelings after his face softens and he smiles?

[1]**EXPECTED ANSWER**

Haseeb is embarrassed and regrets his sharp response, so he uses a gentler expression and self-mocking humour to repair the moment.

ALLOW

- apologetic / ashamed / uncomfortable about snapping
- he wants to reduce the tension or show he did not intend to be cruel

DO NOT ALLOW

- he is amused by falling
- he remains angry
- he is pleased with himself
- he is simply happy

TEACHER INSIGHT

Credit the emotional implication, not a retelling of the facial movement.

QUESTION 2: USE OF LANGUAGE

Independent selection and explanation of an effective example.

Question 2(e)

Identify one example from lines 69-74 which conveys Abdul Hayee's changed view of the theatre. Explain the impression created.

[3]**EXPECTED ANSWER**

Award 1 mark for a suitable example and up to 2 marks for explaining both its image and how it reveals Abdul Hayee's changed view.

MARKING

Strong examples include:

- "It felt unexpectedly warm from his palm" - the key carries Haseeb's human warmth and emotional connection; the theatre no longer seems merely cold, dead or useless, and Abdul senses the responsibility being passed to him.
- "the damaged sign ... blazed briefly" - although broken, the theatre can still flare into brightness and vitality; Abdul now sees remaining power and dignity in it.
- "not restored, not performing, but still capable of an encore" - the theatre is imagined as a performer able to return for one final meaningful moment; its memories and influence survive despite physical ruin.

ALLOW

- another precise phrase from the extract if its language is analysed and clearly connected to Abdul Hayee's changed attitude

DO NOT ALLOW

- an example copied without explanation
- a general summary of the ending with no focus on language
- "Eventually" or "he did not ask for it back" unless developed convincingly as part of a language-based interpretation
- technique labels without explaining the impression

COMMON ERROR

A relevant quotation normally earns 1 mark. A simple meaning earns a second. Full marks require a developed connection to Abdul Hayee's changed view.

MODEL RESPONSE

Example: "still capable of an encore". The theatre is presented as though it were an actor returning to the stage. Although the building is damaged and about to disappear, Abdul now understands that it can still create one final powerful experience and that its memories remain alive.

AT-A-GLANCE MARKING GRID

Use this page for rapid classroom marking; consult the detailed pages for alternatives and exclusions.

Item	Skill	Answer focus	Marks
1(a)	Explicit detail	One valid sign of neglect from paragraph 1	1
1(b)	Own words	Determined/forceful movement + proud return/reclaiming status	2
1(c)(i)	Retrieval	Both names on brass star	1
1(c)(ii)	Inference	Pain/grief caused by Sameera's name or memory	1
1(d)	Physical evidence	His back straightened when he stepped on stage	1
1(e)	Feeling + support	Embarrassed/regretful + two supporting details	3
1(f)	Inference	Script is delicate/precious + emotionally important	2
1(g)	Two details	Any two of Sameera's major theatrical contributions	2
1(h)	Whole-text change	Any three distinct feelings with textual support	3
2(a)	Two impressions	Theatre gloomy/neglected + Haseeb revived/transformed	2
2(b)	Image effect	Lever stiff/resistant + aged/brittle/decayed	2
2(c)	Word choice	Light pours/spreads/pools like liquid	1
2(d)	Feeling	Embarrassed/regretful; softens reaction through humour	1
2(e)	Select + explain	Relevant example + literal image + changed-view connection	3

FINAL CONSISTENCY CHECK

- ✓ Own-words questions reward communicated meaning, not isolated synonym substitution.
- ✓ Feeling + evidence questions award the feeling separately from each distinct supporting detail.
- ✓ Whole-text answers must show different stages or attitudes, not three versions of one idea.
- ✓ Question 2 answers must explain a precise suggestion or connotation of the quoted wording.
- ✓ For Question 2(e), the example and explanation must work together; an unsupported quotation does not earn full marks.